

The Last Word

Keep It Simple

SOME OF MY new *Digit* colleagues are surprised by my insistence on always using the simplest approaches to technology, particularly when it comes to things like file formats. There are several reasons for this, and a recent news story, to which I will return, reminded me of one of them.

For a start, the more complex anything is, the more likely it is that something will go wrong, and the more difficult it is likely to be to fix it. Also, can you trust the developer or manufacturer concerned to understand their own products? Several years ago, during a conference call to Microsoft technical experts in the US, during a discussion of the contents of a Word doc file, I drew their attention to about 70k of ASCII text near the front of the file. I called it ASCII text because using a simple viewer like Ztree, it was perfectly readable. The “experts” corrected me, and told me that this was in fact “compressed Unicode”. In order to prove their point, they drew my attention to about 70k of zero bytes towards the end of the file — these were all the zero bytes from the otherwise Unicode characters stored temporarily.

This is the word-processing equivalent of hearing the electrician wiring your house shout out to his mate “Which one is live? Red or black?” Hand on heart, I actually heard that once, and no, I will never use Word as my main text processor. Never. The other main reason that I prefer simplicity is so that I can access files over a long period of time. Will I want to be able to read this column in 10, even 25 years’ time? I doubt it, but I certainly have plenty of files from about 25 years ago that I do wish to be able to access, and sometimes do.

The rate of change in the PC world is fast, but this does carry with it problems. Not only is the technology advancing quickly, you also have companies apparently introducing gratuitous changes into file formats in order to force people to change to new versions of the software. Hint: if anybody sends you a docx file, just send it back and insist on a more simple format.

My old text files are all plain ASCII, but what if they had been written using WordStar? Would I be able to open them now? Even if that were possible, I cannot count on it being so in another 25 years. I have already “lost” some early image files because I can no longer find anything to open them.

And then there is Adobe’s PDF format. The news item that caught my attention concerned the recent adoption of one of the PDF formats as a published ISO standard. As an increasing amount of material is being stored in pdf files, this is an important and vital step. The point is that unless we know that we will for certain be able to open these files in the distant future, I do not think the verb “archive” should be used here.

When I heard this news and chased around the Internet for further information, I came across the comment that we



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could now be confident that we would be able to open such files “50 years from now”. Wow! 50 years from now! I have often read books in libraries in this country and the UK that go back to up to 1,000 years — and their “file formats” have stood the test of time. I mention libraries because one librarian told me not long ago that the advent of first microfiche and later PDFs had caused some library bean-counters to suggest that they could now do away with boring old paper books. Such people should not be allowed within a mile of a library!

Although the PDF format is complex, making it an ISO standard is at least a step in the right direction (and no doubt good business for Adobe). But we need more companies to take on board the concept that at least for many users, our work is valuable and important and we wish it to have a very long shelf life — at least as long as the dusty old books that can be found in libraries. Rapid change is good for business, productivity, and in these times, the economy, but these machines are called “productivity tools”, so the industry should make sure that the value of the work we produce with them is not swept aside by “progress”.

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